

thorough check. They are looking for fundamental compatibility at every level. It's their job to find any red flags or potential deal breakers. What assets will be brought into the marriage? Is there debt? Are there long-term liabilities? Will this person be a good provider? Will he or she create stability in the home? Will he or she be a good parent?

It goes both ways, of course. Just as the people on your side are vetting your potential mate, you, too, are being vetted. Your mother or aunt is working with her counterpart on the other side, and together they're taking a long, hard look at what each family will bring to this marriage and why they should or shouldn't endorse it. As a result, you're going to have a formidable infrastructure supporting you as you move forward in this relationship. That's unique. With a love match, you take on every bit of risk yourself. But with arranged marriage, someone else absorbs the risk for you. You'd be a fool not to take advantage of a system that has proven successful for thousands of years.

Perhaps this is why arranged marriage is making a comeback in many cultures. It isn't just the Orthodox Jewish community where matchmakers are thriving. Groups ranging from Southeast Asians to evangelical Christians have begun to adopt the practice. A recent article in the *New York Times* chronicled three American couples who had all been brought together by their families (and one matchmaking service); today, all three are happily married. These men and women were pleasantly surprised to discover they had fallen in love with their partners over time instead of overnight.

At the end of the day, is matchmaking really all that different from your friend at work telling you she knows the perfect girl for you, and then the perfect girl becoming your perfect wife? If your parents are doing their job, they're not going to pick someone you detest; they're going to choose someone you would naturally fall in love with over time. They are seeking someone who will be a good match for you, a compatible partner who will *also* provide a lifetime of financial security. This is why modern matchmakers can charge a pretty penny (one upscale matchmaking service charges clients between \$50,000 and \$500,000 to find the partner of their dreams).